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THE QUEST FOR THE 100TH HUNDRED

India’s first international engagement after the World Cup was a tour of the West Indies in June 2011. I was allowed to opt out because India had a busy year ahead and I was desperate to spend some time with my family. I had been playing continuous cricket for eight months and realized that if I travelled to the West Indies it would mean I had not spent much time with Anjali and the children for close to twenty months. India had a number of assignments coming up and this was the one tour that coincided with the kids’ summer holidays. I was on ninety-nine international centuries at the time but it never occurred to me that I should try and get the 100th ton as quickly as possible. Then again, I never imagined that I would have to wait for more than a year.

India in England, July–August 2011

I rejoined the team in July 2011 and was looking forward to playing against a resurgent English side in their home conditions. Under Andrew Strauss they had recently won the Ashes in Australia and were playing some excellent cricket. However, we were still the number-one Test team and it was expected to be a keenly contested series. The fact that our recently appointed coach, Duncan Fletcher, was returning to take on the England team he used to coach with such success also added spice to the series.

For me personally the tour did not start well. My foot started to trouble me on the first day of the tour when we played Somerset in a two-day